

A

Ages and stages in the UK



Age	Stage
0	birth [the moment a baby is born]
Up to 12 months	a baby
12 months – 3 years old	a toddler
3–12 years old	a child: this period is your childhood
13–18 approximately	a teenager : during this period you are in your teens
18+	an adult
40+ approximately	people are middle-aged [in the middle of their lives]
60 or 65	retirement [when people stop work; they are retired]
80+	old age (we usually describe people as elderly)

B

Approximate ages

I'm **in my early twenties** [21–23].

My parents are **in their mid-fifties** [54–56].

My grandmother is **in her late seventies** [77–79].

My grandfather is **nearly/almost eighty** [he's probably 79].

My English teacher's **approximately/roughly** thirty.

[about 30 / more or less 30]

Common mistakes

We can say, **he's 30** or **he's 30 years old**. (NOT he has 30 or he's 30 years)

Also: a **30-year-old man**
(NOT a 30-years-old man)

C

Past and present

PAST AND PRESENT

My grandmother's name was Mary. She's **dead**¹ now. She died about ten years ago when I was in my teens, but I remember her well. She was **brought up**² on a farm in Wales, and her parents were very **strict**: as a teenager, they didn't **allow**³ her to listen to the radio or go to parties in the village. **In the end**⁴, she decided to leave home and get a job in Cardiff. **At first**⁵ it wasn't easy, but she **managed**⁶ to find work, and she also met the man who became her husband: my grandfather. My mother was born four years later. She had a very different childhood. She grew up in the city, she **was allowed to** go to parties, and when she was in her teens, her parents **let**⁷ her **stay out late**⁸. My mum is the same with me.



¹ not living; *opp* **alive**

² looked after until you are an adult

³ give permission

⁴ finally, after a lot of time or thought

⁵ at the beginning

⁶ was able (but it was difficult)

⁷ allowed

⁸ not go home until late

Language help

Let and **allow** have the same meaning. **Let** is slightly more informal, and **allow** is often used in the passive.

My dad **let me drive** his car. I **was allowed to drive** my dad's car.

You're not allowed to smoke in that room. (NOT ~~It's not allowed to~~ smoke in that room.)

Exercises

14.1 Complete the sentences.

- 1 Isabella is only six months old – she’s still a baby .
- 2 Louis was 22 a few months ago, so he’s in his .
- 3 Amelia is 35, so she’s in her .
- 4 Abigail will be 13 this year, so she’ll soon be a .
- 5 William is 53 and his wife is 47, so they’re both .
- 6 Joan is 80 this year, so she is quite .
- 7 Michael was a bus driver for 40 years but he’s now .
- 8 Leon is 18 this year, so legally he becomes .
- 9 The boys are 14 and 16, so they’re both in their .
- 10 Holly is just over a year old and she’s starting to walk, so she’s a . now.

14.2 Are the sentences true or false about Mary’s life on the opposite page? If a sentence is false, change it to make it true.

- 1 Mary was brought up in the city. False. Mary was brought up on a farm.
- 2 She grew up in Wales. .
- 3 Her parents let her do what she wanted. .
- 4 She wasn’t allowed to listen to the radio. .
- 5 Life was easy when she went to Cardiff. .
- 6 She couldn’t get a job in Cardiff. .

14.3 Rewrite the sentences without using the underlined words and phrases. Keep a similar meaning.

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|--|--------------------------------------|
| 1 My parents <u>are dead</u> now. | My parents <u>aren’t alive now</u> . |
| 2 It was hard but <u>finally</u> I did it. | It was hard but . |
| 3 She’s <u>approximately</u> my age. | She’s . |
| 4 They’re <u>almost</u> thirty now. | They’re . |
| 5 <u>I had to do what</u> my parents <u>wanted</u> . | My parents were . |
| 6 My parents <u>let me</u> stay up and watch TV. | I was . |
| 7 My mum <u>looked after me</u> in Scotland. | I was . |
| 8 I <u>was able to</u> pass my exams <u>but it wasn’t easy</u> . | I . |
| 9 I <u>didn’t go home until</u> late. | I . |
| 10 <u>I was allowed to</u> wear what I liked. | My parents . |
| 11 I was happy <u>as a child</u> . | I had a happy . |
| 12 My grandparents <u>don’t work any more</u> . | My grandparents are . |

14.4 Over to you

Answer the questions. If possible, ask a friend and write their answers.

- 1 Where were you brought up? .
- 2 What do you particularly remember about your childhood? .
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- 3 Were your parents strict? What weren’t you allowed to do when you were a child? .
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- 4 How late were you allowed to stay out when you were a teenager? .
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